Introduction: For Real

‘Senor Perez, Senor di Stefano,
ladies and gentlemen…’

Anybody who’s ever played soccer has been inside these dressing rooms. Scuffed tiles on the floor, the smell of disinfectant drifting up from around your ankles. Lines of narrow grey lockers for which you need your own little padlock, their doors stiff from years of being slammed shut a few minutes before kick-off, and one or two missing altogether. Benches in rows so close you’d struggle to slump down opposite a team-mate after a game. One locker door is hanging open at the far end: mine. In the gloom of the dressing room, the brilliant white of the Real Madrid shirt hooked over it is luminous, like a spotlight’s been trained on it. Shorts and socks are folded neatly beneath on the bench. I’m all alone. I can hear muffled conversations going on at the far end of the room, around the door I’d come in. I take my time getting changed, folding my clothes up next to the uniform that’s been left for me. A half-open door leads out to the training field. Beside it, there’s a full-length mirror bolted to the wall. I look the bloke in the mirror up and down. The all-white Real strip seems to make me look big. Makes me feel big. *This is a uniform and a half*. I catch the sound of excited voices. Suddenly I’m aware that I’m looking into my future. There’s a rush of satisfaction, nerves stood on end. *I’m here*.

In fact, we’d been here, in Madrid, nearly 24 hours; long enough for the Beckham family to begin a new life. My Manchester United contract had expired on the last day of June and I’d signed my name at the Bernabeu on the first day of July. Today, July 2, the Real adventure has begun.

We’re all going to be part of what will happen here: I’ve been transferred to a new club and new country but it’s the family who are moving to Spain. I